

Paper / Low-fi Prototype

Sketch or mock an interface in minutes

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A paper or low-fidelity prototype is a rough, hand-made representation of an interface or experience — sketches, paper screens, cardboard mock-ups — built in minutes to test flow and concept before any investment in visuals or code. Its crudeness invites honest critique.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

A long-standing HCI and design practice, championed by the Nielsen Norman Group and IDEO.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

High-fidelity prototypes are slow to make and discourage honest feedback ('it looks finished'). Low-fi versions are fast, cheap and psychologically safe to tear apart.

HOW IT IS USED

Sketch the key screens or touchpoints, then have a user 'operate' the paper while the designer stays silent, noting where the prototype fails to explain itself.

WHEN IT IS USED

Early prototyping, immediately after ideation.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

UX designers, product teams and students.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It maximises **learning per hour** by matching fidelity to the question, keeping ideas disposable while they are still cheap to change.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Minimum Viable Product (MVP) *Slibrary 8*

Wizard of Oz *Slibrary 8*

Usability Testing *Slibrary 9*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Snyder, C. (2003) *Paper Prototyping*. San Francisco: Morgan Kaufmann.

Buxton, B. (2007) *Sketching User Experiences*. San Francisco: Morgan Kaufmann.

FIGURE 1 · CHEAP, FAST, THROWAWAY

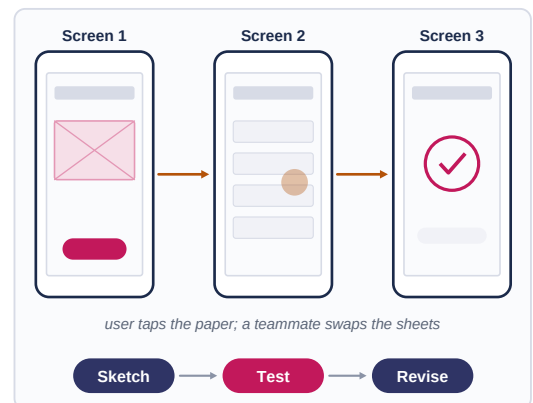


Figure 1. Hand-drawn screens simulate the flow; feedback arrives in minutes, before any code is written.